By *Ambassador* WILLIAM J. SEBALD
with RUSSELL BRINES

WITH MACARTHUR IN JAPAN

A Personal History of the Occupation



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Foreword

THE OCCUPATION OF JAPAN, between 1945 and 1952, was one of those unique developments which so rarely occur in a nation's history. It was an unprecedented attempt by the victorious Allies of the Pacific War, and principally the United States, to remake an entire people as a means of preventing another violent Asian conflict. The results, both good and bad, are clearly visible in today's Japan.

As the senior civilian official in the Occupation hierarchy, I was for a number of years in a position to observe events and to play an active role in implementing policy in Japan. This book is primarily my account of that period. It is also the story of the late General Douglas MacArthur as I saw him during an unusual and prolonged working relationship. Whatever the shortcomings of this Allied experiment, it was wise that MacArthur was appointed the Supreme Commander for the Allied Powers. No American has wielded such vast power over a foreign country with the wisdom and restraint of this victorious general. MacArthur became not only the symbol of the Occupation; to the Japanese people he *was* the Occupation.

The past was definite prologue to Japan's postwar years, and some knowledge of it is helpful in understanding the events of the Occupation. For this reason I have sketched into this story

a number of scenes from my two previous periods of service in Japan. The first, beginning in 1925, brought me as a young United States Navy language officer to a country marked by peace and quiet, order and friendliness. During the thirties, while practicing law in Kobe, I observed the growth of nationalism and rampant imperialism which led to Pearl Harbor and to Japan's inevitable collapse. In less than one generation, from 1925 through 1951, the Japanese actually lived through a complete epoch. They moved swiftly from relative tranquillity to war and defeat and back to stability; from temporary military triumph to hunger and despair, then to revived vitality and confidence.

Japanese history teaches, however, that all this was the norm. Rebellion and war, turbulence and peace are deeply rooted in Japanese society. It is also evident that this long-suffering, remarkable people has developed self-discipline to an unbelievable extent. Were it otherwise, the Occupation, with its discordant pressures, might well have failed.

Against this background I have reconstructed the aspects of the Occupation with which I was directly involved in an attempt to add fresh insight to a historical period of continuing significance. In recounting these events I have drawn liberally upon a journal which I kept faithfully over the years. Quotations attributed to the principal characters are literal contemporary entries as they appear in the journal. The interpretations and conclusions are my own, of course, except where otherwise specified.

Russell Brines has contributed valuable background material accumulated during his service as a newspaper correspondent in Japan between 1939 and 1941 and, again, from 1945 to 1951. For the last five years of this period, he was chief of bureau of The Associated Press in Tokyo and was present at many of the events described in this book.

W.J.S.

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Working with MacArthur

No one knew the private feelings of General MacArthur when he bounded from his personal plane, the *Bataan*, at Atsugi Airfield on August 30, 1945, and stood, at last, on Japanese soil. It would have been surprising and out of character, however, if he had not thought back over the long road from Brisbane, Australia, the dirty, muddy, bloody journey across New Guinea and the Philippines and intervening islands. The end, this end, had never been in doubt for the proud, elderly General with the inflexible will.

Now the man of destiny had arrived in the land of his destiny, unarmed, confident, and in command of the situation. He was, as always, impatient and restless, for there was work to do, after the formal Japanese surrender. The surrender ceremony itself had been delayed for two days, until September 2, because the islands had been lashed by a typhoon, a development symptomatic of events that were about to break over Japan. MacArthur and most of the Allied representatives on this solemn occasion appeared in plain uniforms, without neckties. The Japanese observed strict formality. Foreign Minister Mamoru Shigemitsu and his civilian colleagues wore top hats and morning clothes, a reminder that, after all, this was the Orient.

The surrender ceremony culminated an effort of such unity and well-coordinated skill that the component elements of the

ing the issue, merely to obtain the convenience of my own codes. Accordingly, I told the General I would prefer leaving the situation unchanged. He agreed. But a week later, when I showed him a copy of the Army-State agreement, he said, surprisingly, there was no objection to the use of State Department codes on business which was purely that of State, in which he did not have a primary interest! After some further discussion I was ordered finally in May, 1950, to place our own codes into immediate effect. This accomplishment had taken four years and nine months.

Perhaps the most serious single issue between MacArthur and State Department officials in Washington was over the status and future of Formosa. As early as 1949 this question blew into public controversy. Late in that year the contents of a department guidance paper on Formosa became known to the press, producing headlines in many parts of the world. In essence, the paper cautioned State and USIA officials to prepare the groundwork in their areas for the possible loss of Formosa to the Chinese Communists. It did not, as generally supposed, advocate abandoning the island to the Peking regime, but it outlined a number of arguments minimizing its importance in case the Communists took it over.

I was queried by urgent telegram on the news stories, the inference being that either SCAP or the Diplomatic Section had deliberately leaked the story to the press. MacArthur told me he knew nothing about the incident. Apparently assuming that I had inadvertently disclosed the paper, he offered, however, to help me get out of the difficulty. I said that no one in my section, including myself, had even seen the document, hence we could not be involved in making it public. After considerable telegraphing back and forth, it was discovered that several copies of the guidance had been mailed to the SCAP information officer in an unsealed envelope. The corporal on duty, thinking it was a press release, had given it to a correspondent who happened to be talking to him at the time.

This incident was typical of the kind of minutiae with which

the Supreme Commander frequently was needled by Washington. Perhaps this is inevitable when a huge bureaucracy is involved. But it was also illustrative of the lack of trust and understanding between Washington and Tokyo which appeared from time to time.

It was public knowledge, however, that MacArthur frequently told visitors Formosa should be saved at all costs, if only for its strategic position, while some Washington officials seemed reconciled to its probable loss. Almost as quickly as they established control over the mainland, the Chinese Communists made the capture of Formosa a major goal. MacArthur's attitude on this point was well-expressed during a talk with Karl L. Rankin, who visited Tokyo in July, 1950. The former consul general in Hong Kong, Rankin had just been appointed chargé d'affaires and minister in Taipei, the capital of Formosa, and later would be named ambassador to the Republic of China, headed by Generalissimo Chiang Kai-shek. Speaking of Chiang, MacArthur told Rankin: "If he has horns and a tail, so long as he is anti-Communist, we should help him. Rather than make things difficult, the State Department should assist him in his fight against the Communists—we can try to reform him later!"

A little more than a month after the Korean War erupted, MacArthur and some of his top military staff made a quick visit to Formosa, to confer with Chiang and his generals. This trip, which was never adequately explained, became a significant factor in President Truman's decision to remove General MacArthur from his commands.* It also added further tensions and controversy to SCAP-State relations.

Two days before his departure on July 31, 1950, MacArthur told me of his intention to make the journey. He asked me to send an alerting telegram to our chargé d'affaires, Robert C. Strong, who was in charge of the Embassy until the impending arrival of Rankin. I notified Strong that the SCAP party of sixteen officers would arrive in two C-54 planes; and later I briefly informed

* See pp. 225ff.

Dean Rusk, Assistant Secretary of State for Far Eastern Affairs, when the group left Japan. Otherwise I expected to play no role in the affair.

On August 3, however, the Secretary of State instructed me to ask the General for further information on the Formosa visit. I had seen MacArthur once after his return from the two-day visit to Taipei, but he had appeared tired and promised to tell me about the trip later. When I relayed Secretary Acheson's request for information, MacArthur made it clear that he had no intention of providing details. He replied, in effect, that the talks were purely military in nature, that they were limited to matters of military coordination between the Chinese government and himself as theater commander, and hence what was said and done was his sole responsibility and not that of the State Department. But, I insisted, military agreements of this type could eventually have a direct bearing upon the formulation of foreign policy. The General irritably replied: "Bill, I don't know what you are talking about. The Formosa policy already had been established by President Truman's order of June 28, directing the Seventh Fleet to prevent any Communist attack on the island or any assault from Formosa against the mainland."

The General emphasized, however, as he had once before, that Chinese government officials in Taipei believed the State Department was hostile to them. He evidently accepted this Chinese assessment, and felt that it had a bearing on his responsibility to defend Formosa. Referring to my instructions from Washington, MacArthur said the SCAP reply to State would have been most peremptory if I were not in the middle of this disagreement.

During this interview, as always, MacArthur treated me courteously, despite his deep feelings over the principles involved. But the episode was distasteful to me, for I sensed a growing rift between the American authorities in Tokyo and Washington which, if not corrected, could only lead to disaster.

As a direct result of MacArthur's visit to Formosa, President

Truman sent his roving envoy, W. Averell Harriman, to Tokyo for the announced purpose of briefing MacArthur on American policy. Harriman, all business and bustle behind a friendly manner, accomplished his unusual mission in two days, but no details of his talks with MacArthur were made known, not even to SCAP officials. In fact, the underlying purpose of Harriman's visit never was entirely clear to us in POLAD, although we had a definite stake in it. We could only guess, as did many others, that the President was seeking to reinforce his strict policy that Formosa should not be used as a base of operations against Mainland China.

The Harriman visit did provide a peg for another of the interminable and unfortunate press controversies which helped to exacerbate Tokyo-Washington relations. On the day after Harriman's departure from Tokyo, MacArthur showed me a UP dispatch from Washington which quoted the State Department spokesman as saying, in response to a question, that the department did not know why MacArthur failed to take his political adviser on the visit to Taipei. Nor did he know, the spokesman added, whether the General had given me a report of his conversations with Chinese officials. My comment was that, if I had gone along without permission, I would have had my throat cut. "Not," said MacArthur, "before they had boiled you in oil."

More seriously, I was inclined to ignore the Washington story as a transitory episode in the relentless campaign of the press to generate news whenever possible. I had given no indication, and intended none, that I thought MacArthur should have taken me along with his military staff, in my capacity as his political adviser and State Department representative. On the contrary, I accepted MacArthur's decision on the composition of his staff as one of the peculiarities of my job. The General had not asked me to accompany him to Manila or to Seoul for independence ceremonies, nor had he invited me on his various trips to the Korean War fronts. That simply was MacArthur's way of operating.

It was also his way to attack these press criticisms instead of

shrugging them off. In response to this particular story, he inserted a specific answer in a press release of August 10 explaining the journey to Taipei. The visit, he said, "dealt solely with the problem of preventing military violence to Formosa as directed by the President—the implementation of which directive is my responsibility. It had no connection with political affairs, and, therefore, no suggestion or thought was ever made from any source whatsoever that a political representative accompany me."

My personal reaction to this newspaper skirmish was deep distress that MacArthur should lend himself to protesting too much about small matters, in this case his failure to invite me; an aspect of the episode which Washington quickly indicated was not an issue. I was concerned that these public statements, far from convincing the world that the United States meant business in Asia, gave aid and comfort to the enemy by demonstrating divisions in our leadership and weaknesses in our national purpose.

This, in outline, was the rough-hewn character of the man who represented the victorious Alliance in defeated Japan. But the Alliance itself became the second front in MacArthur's constant skirmishing with the outside world.

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Dismissal of MacArthur; Ridgway as Supreme Commander

THE ABRUPT DISMISSAL of General MacArthur from all his commands in April, 1951, was a climax which had been developing slowly for five and one-half years. During the Occupation, as we have seen, a low-key, smoldering state of misunderstanding was almost continual between Tokyo and Washington. This resulted in occasional resentment on both sides. The Korean War added virtually intolerable burdens. Early in that struggle the President and the General fell into a collision course. It was surprising that the showdown did not occur earlier.

During this long and troubled period the absence of any misunderstanding between MacArthur and Washington would have been most unusual under any circumstances. MacArthur handled his various command responsibilities and the innumerable challenges of the situation in a characteristic way, long familiar to Washington. With his sense of history, experience, seniority, reputation, and temperament, he did not easily compromise when his judgment or his decisions were questioned. Although he knew when to conform to specific superior authority, he did not hesitate to advance his views vigorously. He was never reluctant to interpret his authority broadly or to make decisions and act

quickly—arguing the matter later. Many in Washington remembered these same qualities from World War II and resented them even more in the semipeace of the postwar era.

During the Occupation period, before the Korean War, some of the misunderstandings were critical enough to cause concern. Washington authorities were particularly aroused by instances when, without consultation, MacArthur pursued his own plans until a specific project became a fait accompli and had to be accepted by Washington. I was well-aware of these feelings through my several trips to the capital. The results sometimes made it appear as if the two major centers of Occupation authority were working against each other.

In the Tokyo Headquarters the reaction to Washington policy and guidance often was a sense of frustration. Most SCAP officials believed that Washington did not understand the situation in Japan and that all they needed to complete the Occupation task adequately was clear-cut authority to conduct affairs. There was, of course, some appreciation in Tokyo of the global responsibilities which the United States had assumed and which often governed or influenced the specific policies preferred by Washington. Tokyo was convinced, however, that it felt the cold war more keenly and understood it more thoroughly than did Washington.

This latter point was understandable and, at least until 1948, probably correct. SCAP was confronted at the outset of "peace" by a combination of Soviet power and chicanery which appeared only vaguely recognizable in Washington. The power was visible, for Soviet military force bristled on the nearby mainland and came within sight of Japan Proper, through the occupation of the Habomai Islands, three miles from Hokkaido. In addition to holding hundreds of thousands of Japanese war prisoners, Moscow demonstrated this power by the frequent arrest of Japanese fishing boats near the Habomai and Kurile islands. Along with developments on the continent, these actions provided constant evidence that the might of Soviet Russia stood ready to fill any vacuum created by American misstep or default.

Politically, we had to contend with the ceaseless propaganda and subversive activities of the oversized Soviet Mission. Furthermore, the political pressures and machinations of the Japan Communist Party were a persistent and real threat to the peace and tranquillity of Occupied Japan.

This basic situation became more acute because of the appalling military and political problems of the Korean War. Frustration grew into a sense of futility in both Tokyo and Korea. This stemmed chiefly from the assignment of fighting a "limited" war with patently insufficient forces and under restrictions preventing the full employment of the available power.

Serious misunderstanding between MacArthur and Washington probably began with the General's unannounced journey to Formosa on July 31, 1950.* The trip did not appear to produce any alterations of policy, yet it was a conspicuous point of irritation with Washington. Part of this was caused, I believe, by MacArthur's failure to give due weight to the fact that, under our system of government, foreign policy is made by the President, and that the Department of State recommends and implements this policy. Public dissent with State Department direction, therefore, was in fact a public disagreement with the President. Despite the apparent lack of results from the Formosa visit, MacArthur made it at a time of his own choosing, at a particularly delicate moment, and on the basis of only a very general suggestion from Washington.

The Administration's policy—that is, the policy of the United States government—was to prevent any fighting between Formosa and Mainland China. This was designed to prevent the spread of hostilities in the Far East. It was hoped thereby to give practical evidence that the United States wanted to localize the Korean conflict and, if possible, to contain it below the 38th parallel, as demanded by some friendly governments, notably India. President Truman had ordered the United States Seventh Fleet on June 27 to patrol the Formosa Strait and to prevent any

* See pp. 214ff.

military action from either the Communist mainland or Formosa. In MacArthur's view, this neutralization actually "protected" Communist China from any attack by the Chinese on Formosa, despite the opportunity for such action created by the Korean conflict. The General believed that this "protection" enabled Peking to release two field armies from defense positions in South China and to send them to Manchuria during the summer and early autumn of 1950. These same two armies spearheaded the Chinese Communist attack in Korea.

The neutralization policy raised serious questions and provoked considerable debate, both public and private. Encouraged by Washington's concern over the island and by press speculation that he might visit Formosa to study the situation, MacArthur decided to do so at the first opportunity. This arose on July 31, when United Nations forces in Korea were still locked behind the Perimeter and when intelligence knew that the first of the Chinese Communist units were moving from South China to Manchuria. The offer of three combat divisions for Korea by the Republic of China had been declined more than three weeks earlier.

Immediately upon concluding his visit to Taipei, MacArthur issued this statement:

> My visit to Formosa has been primarily for the purpose of making a short reconnaissance of the potential of its defense against possible attack. The policy has been enunciated that this island, including the Pescadores, is not under present circumstances subject to military invasion. It is my responsibility and firm purpose to enforce this decision.
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> My conferences here on all levels have been most cordial and responsive in every respect. Among the problems which were discussed was the prompt and generous offer of the Chinese Government to send troops to join the United Nations forces in Korea. The belief of all concerned however was that such action at this time might so seriously jeopardize the defense of Formosa that it would be inadvisable.
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> Arrangements have been completed for effective coordination between American forces under my command and those of the Chinese Government, the better to meet any attack which a hostile force might be foolish enough to attempt. Such an attack would, in my opinion, stand little chance of success.

It has been a great pleasure for me to meet my old comrade-in-arms of the last war, Generalissimo Chiang Kai-shek. His indomitable determination to resist Communist domination arouses my sincere admiration. His determination parallels the common interest and purpose of Americans, that all peoples in the Pacific area shall be free—not slave.

This statement visibly upset Washington, because of its clear political implications and its promise of close American and Chinese cooperation for the defense of Formosa. Secretary of State Acheson's instruction to me to ask for more details, therefore, was understandable and was hardly satisfied by the General's reply that, in effect, his "military conversations" were none of the State Department's business. Although MacArthur said he had reported fully to Washington through his own channels, it was never clear in Tokyo whether the State Department was adequately informed of the Taipei talks. In any case, Harriman's visit to Tokyo on August 6 indicated concern on the highest level that MacArthur and Chiang Kai-shek might take action, on their own responsibility, thereby upsetting the careful and delicate balance which the Administration was trying to maintain.

If anything, MacArthur added to this uncertainty by his press release of August 10, issued primarily to answer newspaper speculation that he had a particular purpose in failing to take me with him to Taipei. Emphasizing the military nature of the journey, MacArthur ended his statement with this controversial paragraph:

This visit has been maliciously misrepresented to the public by those who invariably in the past have propagandized a policy of defeatism and appeasement in the Pacific. I hope the American people will not be misled by sly insinuations, brash speculations and bold misstatements invariably attributed to anonymous sources, so insidiously fed them both nationally and internationally by persons 10,000 miles away from the actual events, if they are not indeed designed, to promote disunity and destroy faith and confidence in American purposes and institutions and American representatives at this time of great world peril.[1]

These were MacArthur's sincere sentiments and those of the overwhelming majority of his staff officers at that period of frus-

tration in the Korean War. Washington was sufficiently concerned, however, so that on August 14 Secretary of Defense George C. Marshall sent specific instructions to MacArthur, forbidding authorization of any Nationalist Chinese attack on the mainland. Marshall based the order on the contention that "the most vital national interest requires that no action of ours precipitates general war or gives excuse to others to do so." MacArthur replied that he fully understood the presidential decision of June 27 "to protect the Communist mainland."

The relationship between MacArthur and the Administration changed markedly, if temporarily, after the Inchon landing. The bickering and occasional flashes of temper which had occurred on both sides calmed. The military operation vindicated MacArthur's judgment against all advisers, including most of the Joint Chiefs of Staff. He had demonstrated that a bold policy against the Communist aggressor, by the skillful use of available means, would win. Even President Truman basked in the sunlight of MacArthur's tremendously successful strategic and tactical stroke. It was followed by the crossing of the 38th parallel, the Wake Island meeting, and the entry of powerful Chinese Communist forces into the war.

Although the decision to cross the 38th parallel resulted from apparent total agreement between MacArthur and Washington, fundamental differences of viewpoint over the Korean conflict remained. In particular, they disagreed over the relative importance of Europe and Asia in global strategy, a controversy held over from World War II. MacArthur firmly believed that the Communists would conquer Europe through Asia unless stopped in the Far East. He believed also that both Europe and the United States were shortsighted in failing to accept this premise. The Administration, on the other hand, clearly was following a global strategy. Despite the demands of the Korean War, Washington was increasing and strengthening United States forces in Europe. To a considerable degree, this policy was feasible only if the Korean conflict remained localized and limited, thus requiring